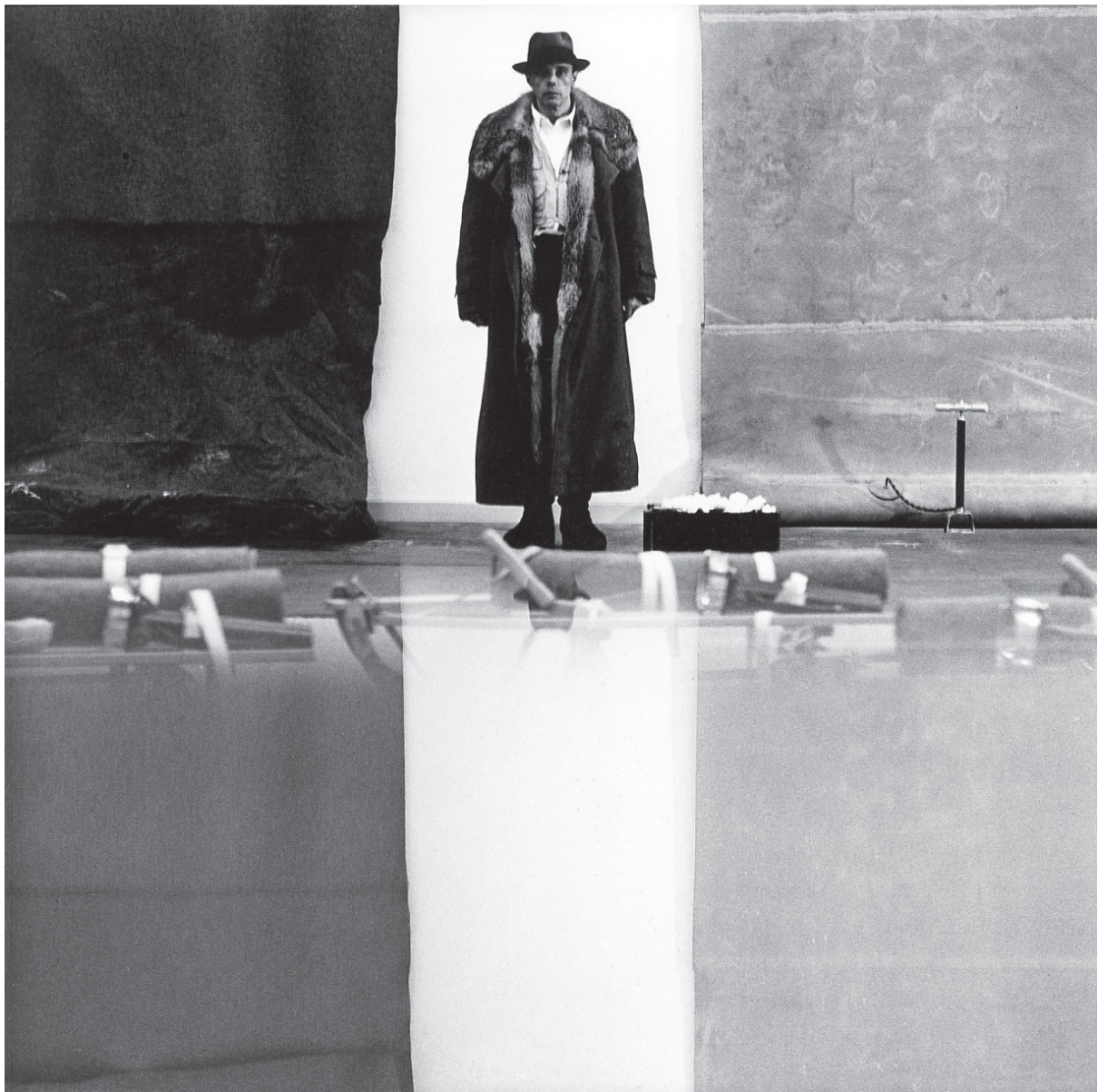


Performance art

Performance art emerged in the 1950s, inspired by diverse ideas including Dada and the Cabaret Voltaire, Abstract Expressionism, Futurist theatrical events, Pop art and the horrors of two world wars. Many Performance artists were also influenced by a 1950 series of photographs by Hans Namuth (1915–90) that showed Jackson Pollock creating Action Paintings.

In the late 1950s, Allan Kaprow (1927–2006) organized interactive events or 'Happenings' in New York. Soon, other artists were using their bodies to express themselves, in dance, mime, singing or acting, often in unexpected locations. Audiences were generally expected to participate, or question aspects of society. Known as Actionism in Austria and Germany, it became quite a phenomenon in the 1960s and 1970s, expressed by artists including Vito Acconci (b.1940), Bruce Nauman (b.1941) and Joseph Beuys (1921–86). Beuys's 'Actions' involved complex allegories of social and political issues. The main purpose of Performance art has nearly always been to challenge the conventions of more traditional art forms.



Beuys with his installation *'The Pack'*, 1969